

SPIN-OFFS

Plot Pourri

Obscure Film Remakes

Searching for that unusual idea, indie filmmakers have fallen prey to borrowing ideas. So if *Bheja Fry* was another version of the French film, *The Dinner Game*, *Ugly Aur Pagli* was of the Korean film, *My Sassy Girl*. And though the makers deny it, there's a startling resemblance



between *Aamir* and the Filipino film *Cavite*.

Word Power First there was the multiplex boom. Then there was arthouse cinema or indie films, all contrasted with the "projects", movies where the star preceded the story. And most of all, "meaningful" roles for mainstream actors.

Different Beats For *Oye Lucky Lucky Oye*, Sneha Khanwalkar transported one of the singers from a village in Punjab, for she wanted the sound to be authentic. Most independent films have



led to a spurt of new music directors with alternative sounds, mostly interesting, sometimes jarring. *Khosla Ka Ghosla* had Bapi-Tutul, *Life in a Metro* was Pritam's ticket to fame, *Jhankaar Beats* made Vishal-Shekhar a rage, and *Dev.D* made Amit Trivedi a star.

Offbeat Themes Adultery, terrorism, homosexuality: indie films discovered them; mainstream movies embraced them.

ANURAG KASHYAP'S DEV.D, A MODERN TAKE ON DEVDAS, STUNNED VIEWERS WITH ITS AUDACITY

INDIA NEEDS BETTER producers rather than screenwriters. No producer wants to invest in out-of-the-way scripts..

ANURAG KASHYAP, FILMMAKER

maybe your list is bigger than mine but think about it—how many would you include in that list? Eight, 12, 20? It is still a pitifully small number and I am not talking only of Hindi films. And then there is the 'independent cinema trap'. Just because one makes a low-budget film doesn't mean it is an independent film. I have seen as many awful small budget films as the mainstream ones and to be honest, if I had to choose between the two, I would prefer big budget nonsense—at least they work hard at the song picturisation. I don't think the budget qualifies your film as independent or otherwise.

I would like to think independent means that the film is independent of all the external forces—the market, the current fads, the expectations of the viewers, the prevalent ideology. A film that has a vision, a director who has a world view in the first place and a facility to express that world in

2006 Often produced independently, multiplex films find takers in big production houses. UTV, Pritish Nandy Communication and Percept Picture Company

give it a boost.

2007 The indie film gets a corporate makeover. UTV launches UTV Spotboy to spearhead films on small budgets but big ideas.

2008 World cinema gets a platform. Numerous festivals and societies start bringing films from all over the world to Indian screens. PVRs and BIG Cinemas screen foreign films.

his unique way. Only then can a film be categorised as an independent film.

This year my list would include Anurag Kashyap's *Dev.D*, Paresh Mokashi's *Harishchandrachi Factory* and Paresh Kamdar's *Khargosh*—three wonderful films that have the mark of the respective filmmaker on every frame and present a world and a vision, uniquely theirs.

For me, Ram Gopal Verma's *Satya* and *Company* had the signature of an auteur and so did *Swades*. So it is not about the budget or the presence of stars that defines what is independent and what isn't. A mega budget studio-backed project like *The Dark Knight* is as independent a work as any film by Lars von Trier. I think Sanjay Leela Bhansali has it in him to make a truly independent film on a huge budget. But I am weary of these wannabes, who have jumped on the bandwagon lately, pretending to be making independent films but are actually churning out the same conventional mainstream films, only without the stars. The other big danger is that we have forgotten the other India, like most others living in this country. We make films about our lives, oblivious of the other. Nothing wrong with it. If the filmmakers are being honest and saying that this is the world of my experience, this is the only world I know and the only truth I can honestly portray. Fine but does it mean that we will only make films about upper-class India? Is there no filmmaker out there who is moved by the trials of the rest of the country?

The multiplexes too have their biases. If it is a comedy, yes; love story, yes; urban gangster film, yes. But let it be a city film please, so that our city audience can identify with it. So even as we celebrate the rise of the new Indian cinema, will Paresh Kamdar's brilliant *Khargosh* ever find a multiplex release? I think no.

Will first time producer Rishi Chandra, who put his own money to make this film, ever recover his investment? The honest answer is, probably not. But it is the courage, passion, rigour and vision of individuals like these that will lay the foundations of some wonderful work in the next decade. Or so we would like to tell ourselves.

Rajat Kapoor is a filmmaker, actor and writer

